

BEFORE

A variety of factors have been blamed for starting the demise of the Roman Empire.

THE FADING OF ANTIQUITY

Under the *pax romana*, the Romans ruled a Mediterranean empire that was united by a Greco–Roman classical culture based on the value of the city. This classical civilization came to be threatened in places by recurring civil wars, economic pressures, and the wholesale influx of non-Roman people that took place toward the end of the 2nd century CE.



PERSIAN COIN

RISING PERSIAN POWER

The period of crisis in the Roman Empire during the 3rd century CE << 112–13 was, in part, caused by the newly rejuvenated Persian Empire under the rule of Ardashir, who became the first “king of kings” (*Shah-an-shah*) or emperor of the Sassanid Empire << 122–23 in 226 CE. Between 230–60 CE the Persians defeated the Romans on three occasions, capturing and killing Emperor Valerian in 260 CE.

FRONTIERS CRUMBLE

“Barbarian” pressure built up along the Rhine and Danube rivers in the 3rd century CE, leading to continual incursions. This had been a major migration route for thousands of years. The Romans had been fighting against a tide greater and older than themselves for a long time.

KING OF THE HUNS (406–453 CE)

ATTILA THE HUN

King of the “Huns” (steppe nomads from inner Asia) between 434 and 453, Attila was the scourge of the Roman world. By the 400s, the Huns controlled a sizable territory in Eastern Europe. Attila aimed to maintain a steppe empire placed strategically on the Hungarian plains, at the doorway to Western Europe. He subdued neighboring tribes and won victories over the eastern Romans, even extracting tribute money from them.



The date of 476 CE is often given as the end of the Roman Empire. This was the year Romulus Augustulus was deposed as emperor. He was, however, a “puppet” child king with a tenuous claim to leadership, and was emperor of only the western empire of Rome. He was removed by Germanic chief, Odoacer, who, though often portrayed as a barbarian warlord, was actually a former Roman commander in Italy.

Collapse would not occur for some time, and it is important to note that while the western empire declined,

progress often pushed such groups into other lands—sometimes Roman territory—where they became allies of the empire and helped defend the Romans against Huns and other tribes.

Cooperation and conflict

In fact, it was not unusual for Germanic groups to become official Roman allies, or “federated” people gaining certain Roman-style rights. The situation was far more complex than a



The last emperor
Romulus Augustulus is seen
as the last emperor of
Rome's western empire.

simple “barbarians versus Romans” scenario where one side rose and the other fell. Within the imperial system there were commanders and statesmen of Germanic blood. At different times, barbarians either sided with or fought

against the Romans, as well as other barbarian groups. For example, the Goths defeated Emperor Valens in 378, at the Battle of Adrianople (Turkey), crushing the imperial army so severely that the Danube borders were left open

Decline and Fall?

The 5th century CE saw a massive shift in the world's map as the western Roman Empire faded, and a patchwork of new “barbarian” kingdoms dominated Europe. The eastern Roman Empire flourished as the Byzantine culture evolved there. It has been viewed alternately as a time of decline or one of transition.

the eastern Roman Empire, established in the early 4th century CE by Emperor Constantine (see pp.113, 149), thrived. Greco-Roman culture prospered there initially, although it evolved into a highly influential Christian Byzantine civilization that would last for another thousand years (see pp.198–99).

The time can be seen in a positive light and in some ways as one of continuity, rather than bleakly as the end of refined “civilization” when Europe was plunged into chaos. “Decline and fall” was the phrase famously coined by 18th-century English historian Edward Gibbon, to describe the end of the Roman Empire, but the period could also be viewed as one of transition.

The great migrations

By the 4th and 5th centuries CE, a variety of peoples—many from Eurasia's northern steppe lands—had gained a strong foothold in European and Middle Eastern territories once dominated by the Romans. Germanic kingdoms and tribes spread far and wide during these centuries—for example, the Visigoths in parts of France (a kingdom was founded at Toulouse in 418 CE), Spain, Greece, and Italy; Franks in France; the Vandals in North Africa (their kingdom was founded there in 429 CE); and the Sueves in Spain. In 410 CE the Romans officially withdrew from Britain, where the Celts prevailed before Angles and Saxons arrived on British shores.

In the later 4th century CE, westward-migrating Hunnic people defeated and forced semi-sedentary people living around the Black Sea area to flee. Their



Showing Roman soldiers striking heroic poses and in command of the situation, this is a powerful piece of imperial propaganda.

Distinctive beards, hairstyles, and clothing mark out the barbarians, who are all shown in agonized submission.